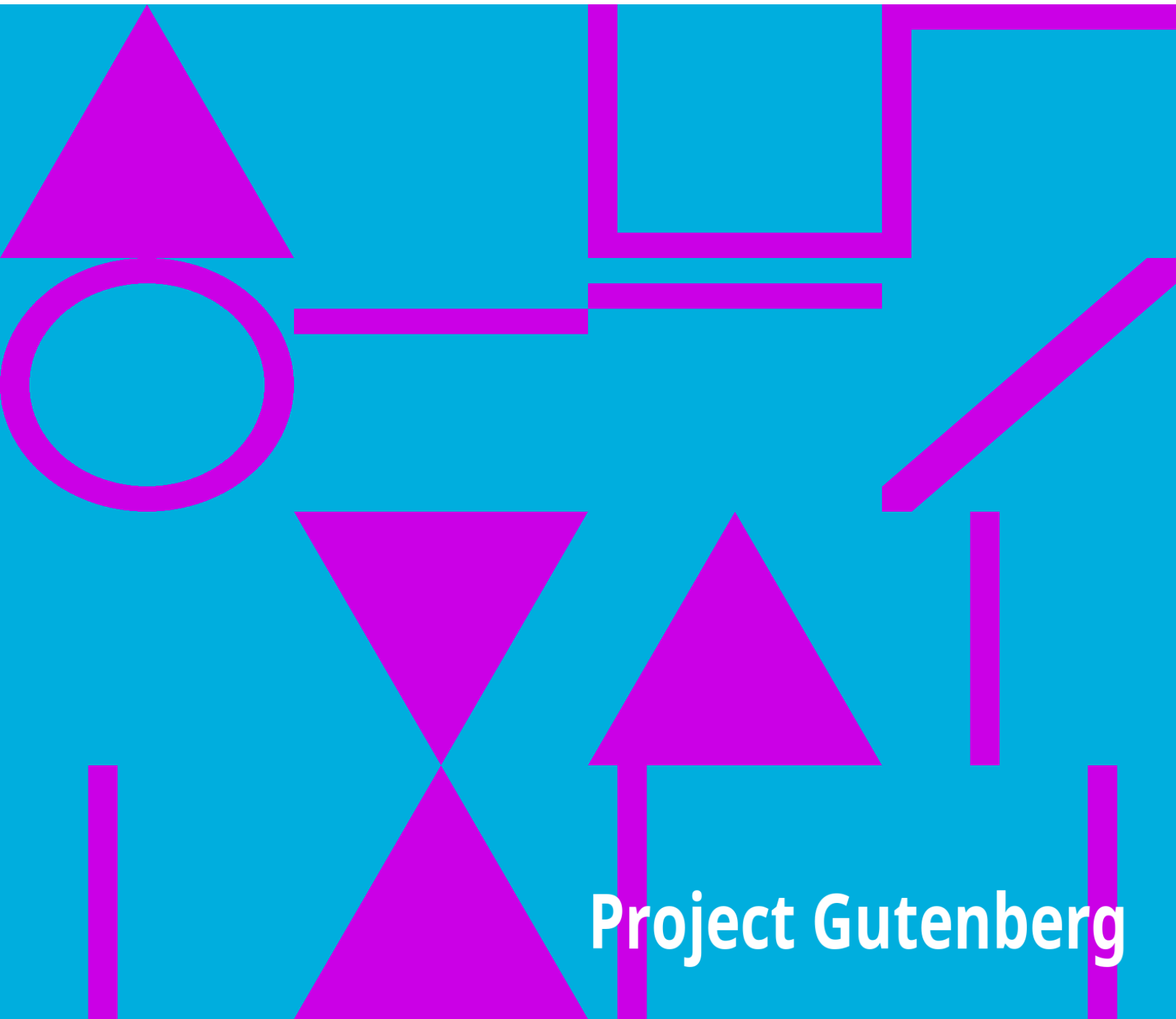


A Lowden Sabbath Morn

Robert Louis Stevenson



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Robert Louis Stevenson



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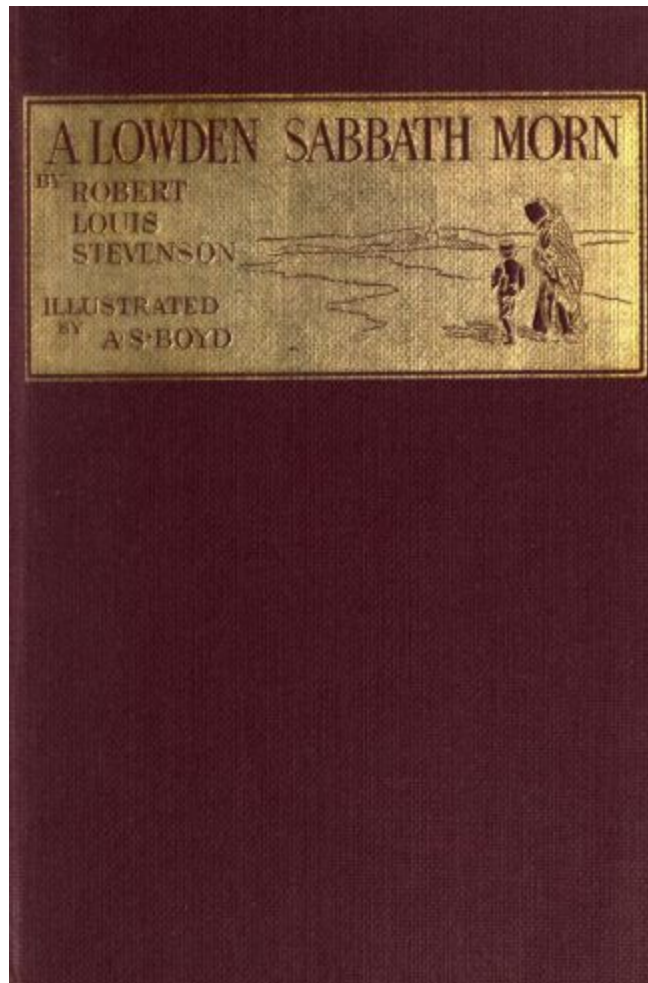
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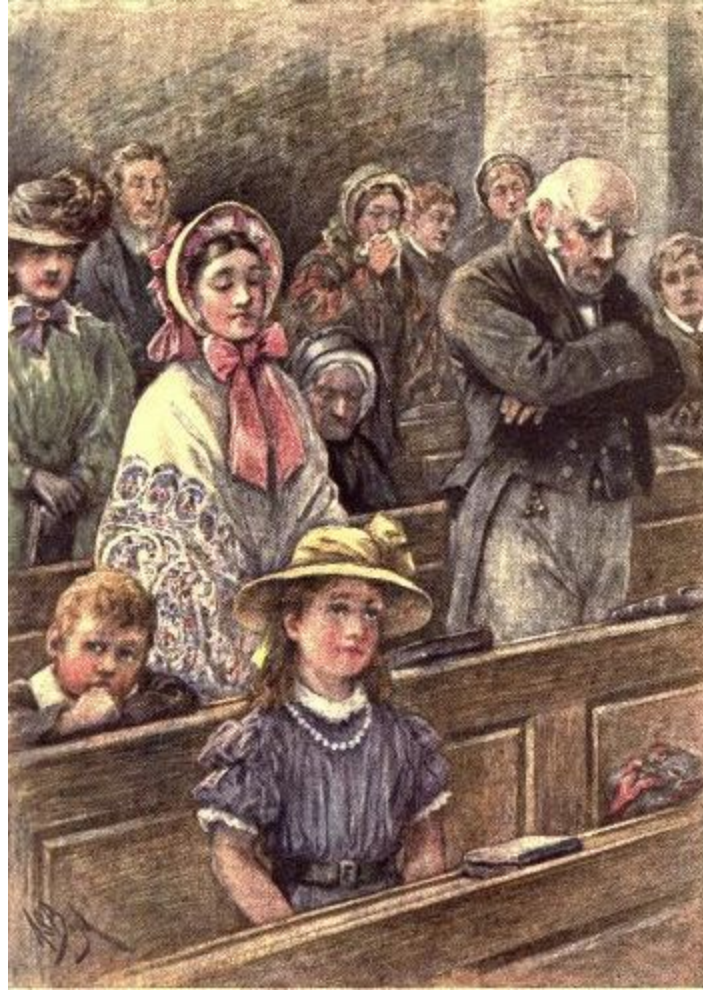
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SABBATH MORN ***



A LOWDEN SABBATH MORN



THE PRAYER

p. 16

**A LOWDEN 🍀 🍀
SABBATH MORN**

**BY ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON
ILLUSTRATED BY A. S. BOYD**

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**TO
THE MEMORY OF
ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON
THIS BOOK IS DEDICATED
BY
THE ILLUSTRATOR**

A Lowden Sabbath Morn

I

The clinkum-clank o'
Sabbath bells
Noo to the hoastin' rookery
swells,
Noo faintin' laigh in shady
dells,
Sounds far an'
near,
An' through the simmer
kintry tells
Its tale o' cheer.

II

An' noo, to that melodious
play,
A' deidly awn the quiet sway

A' ken their solemn holiday,
Bestial an' human,
The singin' lintie on the brae,
The restin'
plou'man.

III

He, mair than a' the lave o'
men,
His week completit joys to
ken;
Half-dressed, he daunders
out an' in,
Perplext wi'
leisure;
An' his raxt limbs he'll rax
again
Wi' painfü'
pleasure.

IV

The steerin' mither strang afit
Noo shoos the bairnies but a
bit;
Noo cries them ben, their
Sinday shüit
To scart upon
them,
Or sweeties in their pouch to
pit,
Wi' blessin's on
them.

V

The lasses, clean frae tap to
taes,
Are busked in crunklin'
underclaes;
The gartened hose, the weel-
filled stays,
The nakit shift,
A' bleached on bonny greens
for days

An' white's the
drift.

VI

An' noo to face the kirkward
mile:
The guidman's hat o' dacent
style,
The blackit shoon, we noo
maun fyle
As white's the
miller:
A waefü' peety tae, to spile
The warth o' siller.

VII

Our Marg'et, aye sae keen to
crack,
Douce-stappin' in the stoury
track,

Her emerald gown a' kiltit
back
Frae snawy coats,
White-ankled, leads the
kirkward pack
Wi' Dauvit Groats.

VIII

A thocht ahint, in runkl'd
brecks,
A' spiled wi' lyin' by for
weeks,
The guidman follows closs,
an' cleiks
The sonsie missis;
His sarious face at aince
bespeaks
The day that this
is.

IX

And aye an' while we nearer
draw
To whaur the kirkton lies
alaw,
Mair neebours, comin' saft
an' slaw
Frae here an' there,
The thicker thrang the gate,
an' caw
The stour in air.

X

But hark! the bells frae
nearer clang;
To rowst the slaw, their sides
they bang;
An' see! black coats a'ready
thrang
The green
kirkyaird;
And at the yett, the chestnuts
spang

That brocht the
laird.

XI

The solemn elders at the
plate
Stand drinkin' deep the pride
o' state:
The practised hands as gash
an' great
As Lords o'
Session;
The later named, a wee thing
blate
In their expression.

XII

The prentit stanes that mark
the deid,
Wi' lengthened lip, the
sarious read;

Syne wag a moraleesin' heid,
An' then an' there
Their hirplin' practice an'
their creed
Try hard to square.

XIII

It's here our Merren lang has
lain,
A wee bewast the table-
stane;
An' yon's the grave o' Sandy
Blane;
An' further ower,
The mither's brithers, dacent
men!
Lie a' the fower.

XIV

Here the guidman sall bide
awee

To dwell amang the deid; to
see
Auld faces clear in fancy's
e'e;
Belike to hear
Auld voices fa'in saft an' slee
On fancy's ear.

XV

Thus, on the day o' solemn
things,
The bell that in the steeple
swings
To fauld a scaattered faim'ly
rings
Its walcome
screed;
An' just a wee thing nearer
brings
The quick an' deid.

XVI

But noo the bell is ringin' in;
To tak their places, folk
begin;
The minister himsel' will
shüne
Be up the gate,
Filled fu' wi' clavers about
sin
An' man's estate.

XVII

The tünes are up—*French*, to
be shüre,
The faithfü' *French*, an' twa-
three mair;
The auld prezenter, hoastin'
sair,
Wales out the
portions,
An' yirks the tüne into the air
Wi' queer
contortions.

XVIII

Follows the prayer, the
 readin' next,
An' than the fisslin' for the
 text—
The twa-three last to find it,
 vext
 But kind o' proud;
An' than the peppermints are
 raxed,
 An' southernwood.

XIX

For noo's the time whan
 pows are seen
Nid-noddin' like a
 mandareen;
When tenty mithers stap a
 preen
 In sleepin' weans;

An' nearly half the parochine
Forget their pains.

XX

There's just a waukrif' twa or
three:
Thrawn commentautors
sweer to 'gree,
Weans glowrin' at the
bumlin' bee
On windie-glasses,
Or lads that tak a keek a-gee
At sonsie lasses.

XXI

Himsel', meanwhile, frae
whaur he cocks
An' bobs belaw the soundin'-
box,
The treesures of his words
unlocks

Wi' prodigality,
An' deals some unco dingin'
knocks
To infidelity.

XXII

Wi' sappy unction, hoo he
burkes
The hopes o' men that trust in
works,
Expounds the fau'ts o' ither
kirks,
An' shaws the best
o' them
No muckle better than mere
Turks,
When a's confessed
o' them.

XXIII

Bethankit! what a bonny
creed!

What mair would ony
Christian need?—

The braw words rumm'le
ower his heid,

Nor steer the
sleeper;

And in their restin' graves,
the deid

Sleep aye the
deeper.

AUTHOR'S NOTE

It may be guessed by some that I had a certain parish in my eye, and this makes it proper I should add a word of disclamation. In my time there have been two ministers in that parish. Of the first I have a special reason to speak well, even had there been any to think ill. The second I have often met in private and long (in the due phrase) "sat under" in his church, and neither here nor there have I heard an unkind or ugly word upon his lips. The preacher of the text had thus no original in that particular parish; but when I was a boy he might have been observed in many others; he was then (like the schoolmaster) abroad; and by recent advices, it would seem he has not yet entirely disappeared.

ILLUSTRATOR'S NOTE

I am not certain of the particular parish Stevenson had in his mind when he wrote this poem, but I am certain that the description is typical of almost any Scottish rural parish, Lowden (that is, *Lothian*) or other. In illustrating the verses it has seemed to me, therefore, unnecessary to make portraits from any one locality. I fancy the writer looked back to the period of his boyhood and to the people he knew in more than one part of his native country, so I have tried to depict that period and that class of people as I remember them in various counties of his land and mine.

A. S. B.



*The clinkum-clank o' Sabbath bells
Noo to the hoastin' rookery swells,
Noo faintin' laigh in shady dells,
 Sounds far an' near,
An' through the simmer kintry tells
 Its tale o' cheer.*



*An' noo, to that melodious play,
A' deidly awn the quiet sway—
A' ken their solemn holiday,
 Bestial an' human,
The singin' lintie on the brae,
 The restin' plou'man.*



*He, mair than a' the lave o' men,
His week completit joys to ken;
Half-dressed, he daunders out an' in,
Perplext wi' leisure;
An' his raxt limbs he'll rax again
Wi' painfü' pleasure.*



*The steerin' mither strang afit
Noo shoos the bairnies but a bit;
Noo cries them ben, their Sinday
shüit*

*To scart upon them,
Or sweeties in their pouch to pit,
Wi' blessin's on them.*



*The lasses, clean frae tap to taes,
Are busked in crunklin' underclaes;
The gartened hose, the weel-filled
stays,
The nakit shift,
A' bleached on bonny greens for
days,*

An' white's the drift.



*An' noo to face the kirkward mile:
The guidman's hat o' dacent style,
The blackit shoon, we noo maun fyle
As white's the miller:
A waefü' peety tae, to spile
The warth o' siller.*



*Our Marg'et, aye sae keen to crack,
Douce-stappin' in the stoury track,
Her emeralt gown a' kiltit back
Frae snawy coats,
White-ankled, leads the kirkward
pack
Wi' Dauvit Groats.*

A thocht ahint, in runkled breeks,

*A' spiled wi' lyin' by for weeks,
The guidman follows closs, an' cleiks
The sonsie missis;
His sarious face at aince bespeaks
The day that this is.*



*And aye an' while we nearer draw
To whaur the kirkton lies alaw,
Mair neebours, comin saft an' slaw
Frae here an' there,
The thicker thrang the gate, an' caw
The stour in air.*



*But hark! the bells frae nearer
clang;
To rowst the slaw, their sides they
bang;
An' see! black coats a'ready thrang
The green kirkyaird;
And at the yett, the chestnuts spang
That brocht the laird.*



*The solemn elders at the plate
Stand drinkin' deep the pride o'
state:*

*The practised hands as gash an'
great*

*As Lords o' Session;
The later named, a wee thing blate
In their expression.*



*The prentit stanes that mark the
deid,
Wi' lengthened lip, the sarious read;
Syne wag a moraleesin' heid,
An' then an' there
Their hirplin' practice an' their creed
Try hard to square.*



*It's here our Merren lang has lain,
A wee bewast the table-stane;
An' yon's the grave o' Sandy Blane;
An' further ower,
The mither's brithers, dacent men!
Lie a' the fower.*



*Here the guidman sall bide awee
To dwall amang the deid; to see
Auld faces clear in fancy's e'e;
Belike to hear
Auld voices fa'in saft an' slee
On fancy's ear.*



*Thus, on the day o' solemn things,
The bell that in the steeple swings
To fauld a scaittered faim'ly rings
 Its walcome screed;
An' just a wee thing nearer brings
 The quick an' deid.*



*But noo the bell is ringin' in;
To tak their places, folk begin;*



*The minister himsel' will shüne
Be up the gate,
Filled fu' wi' clavers about sin
An' man's estate.*



*The tünes are up—French, to be
shüre,
The faithfü' French, an' twa-three
mair;
The auld prezenter, hoastin' sair,
Wales out the portions,
An' yirks the tüne into the air
Wi' queer contortions.*



*Follows the prayer, the readin' next,
An' than the fisslin' for the text—
The twa-three last to find it, vext
But kind o' proud;*



*An' than the peppermints are raxed,
An' southernwood.*



*For noo's the time whan pows are
seen
Nid-noddin' like a mandareen;
When tenty mithers stap a preen
In sleepin' weans;
An' nearly half the parochine
Forget their pains.*



*There's just a waukrif' twa or three:
Thrawn commentautors sweer to
'gree,*



*Weans glowrin' at the bumlin' bee
On windie-glasses,
Or lads that tak a keek a-gee
At sonsie lasses.*



*Himself, meanwhile, frae whaur he
cocks*

*An' bobs below the soundin'-box,
The treasures of his words unlocks
Wi' prodigality,
An' deals some unco dingin' knocks
To infidelity.*



*Wi' sappy unction, hoo he burkes
The hopes o' men that trust in works,
Expounds the fau'ts o' ither kirks,
An' shaws the best o' them
No muckle better than mere Turks,
When a's confessed o'
them.*

Bethankit! what a bonny creed!

*What mair would ony Christian
need?—*



*The braw words rumm'le ower his
heid,
Nor steer the sleeper;*



*And in their restin' graves, the deid
Sleep aye the deeper.*



WORKS BY ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

AN INLAND VOYAGE.
EDINBURGH: PICTURESQUE
NOTES.
TRAVELS WITH A DONKEY.
VIRGINIBUS PUERISQUE.
FAMILIAR STUDIES OF MEN
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